

Herbs that Relieve Food Stagnation

- Promote digestive function to strengthen the Spleen, enhance the appetite, promote digestion, and relieve food stagnation.
- Treatment of digestive problems must always include assessment of the Spleen and Stomach. However, these disorders are often accompanied by complications.
- For heat secondary to food stagnation in the middle jiao, qi-regulating herbs should be added for maximum effectiveness.
- For heat secondary to food stagnation, incorporate heat-clearing herbs.
- For damp accumulation secondary to food stagnation, add aromatic herbs to dissolve dampness and awaken the Spleen
- If there is accumulation of cold, include interior-warming herbs
- In severe cases of food stagnation, purgative herbs can be added

Name	Similarities	Differences
Shan Zha (<i>Fructus Crataegi</i>)	Reduce food stagnation, strengthen the Stomach	Digests meat, invigorates blood and disperses blood stasis
Shen Qu (<i>Massa Fermentata</i>)		Breaks down hard-to-digest foods, protects the Stomach
Mai Ya (<i>Fructus Hordei Germinatus</i>)		Digests starch, inhibits lactation
Gu Ya (<i>Fructus Setariae Germinatus</i>)		Digests starch, best for weak patients
Lai Fu Zi (<i>Semen Raphani</i>)		Relieves fullness and distention, descends Lung qi and dispels phlegm
Ji Nei Jin (<i>Endothelium Corneum Gigeriae Galli</i>)		Strongly reduces food stagnation, consolidates jing (essence), softens and dissolves stones.

Shān Zhā 山楂

“mountain hawthorn”

Fructus Crataegi

English: hawthorn fruit, crataegus

Properties: sour, sweet, slightly warm

Channels: Liver, Spleen, Stomach

Actions and Indications

Actions: Reduces and guides out food stagnation:

Indications – for accumulation due to meat or greasy foods with accompanying symptoms of abdominal distention, pain, or diarrhea.

- Shan Zha is **Yao Yao** for treating food stagnation due to meat and greasy food.
- Difficulty digesting meat products: Use *Shan Zha* individually.
- General indigestion and food stagnation: use with *Shen Qu*.
- Indigestion with abdominal distention and pain: *Mu Xiang, Zhi Ke*
- Indigestion with diarrhea: use 10 grams of charred *Shan Zha* as an herbal powder.

Actions: Invigorates blood and disperses blood stasis

Indications – for post-partum abdominal pain and clumps due to blood stasis

Main Actions:

- Reduces and guides out food stagnation
- Invigorates blood and disperses blood stasis

Dosage: 10-15 grams. The maximum dose of Shan Zha is 30 grams. The unprocessed herb dissolves food stagnation and activates blood circulation. Charred herbs increase their bitter taste and enhance their actions in reducing abdominal distension and relieving diarrhea.

Review questions

- Properties, actions, and indications of Shan Za
- What herb is particularly used to treat food stagnation from meat and greasy food?
- What herb is used for moving the blood?

Shén Qū 神曲

Massa Fermentata

English: medicated leaven, shen-chu

Properties: sweet, acrid, **warm**

Channels: Spleen, Stomach

Actions and Indications

Actions: Reduces food stagnation and harmonizes the ST:

Indications – for ST cold with food stagnation or accumulation, with such symptoms as epigastric and abdominal fullness or distention, lack of appetite, borborygmus, and diarrhea

Mài Yá 麦芽

- *Fructus Hordei Vulgaris Germinantus*
- **English:** barley sprout, malt
- **Properties:** sweet, **neutral**
- **Channels:** Liver, Spleen, Stomach

Actions and Indications

Actions: Reduces food stagnation and strengthens the ST.

Indications – for poor digestion due to stagnation and accumulation of undigested starchy foods, as well as poorly digested milk in infants

Actions: Inhibits lactation.

Indications – for women who are discontinuing nursing or for distended and painful breasts

Actions: Facilitates the smooth flow of Liver qi.

Indications – for constrained Liver qi or Liver overacting on Spleen, manifesting as a stifling sensation and distention in the epigastrium or ribs, belching, and loss of appetite.

Gǔ Yá 谷芽

Fructus Oryzae Sativae Germinantus

English: rice sprout

Properties: sweet, **neutral**

Channels: Spleen, Stomach

Actions and Indications

Actions: Reduces food stagnation and strengthens the ST.

Indications – for poor digestion due to stagnation and accumulation of undigested starchy foods; also for weak digestion and loss of appetite associated with Spleen deficiency.

Lái Fú Zǐ 莱菔子

Semen Raphani Sativi

English: radish seed, raphanus

Properties: acrid, sweet, **neutral**

Channels: Lung, Spleen, Stomach

Actions and Indications

Actions: Reduces food stagnation and transforms accumulation.

Indications – for food stagnation accumulating in the middle burner with fullness and distention, belching with a rotten smell, acid regurgitation or abdominal pain with difficult diarrhea. *Shan Zha, Shen Qu, Chen Pi*

Actions: Causes qi to descend and reduces phlegm:

Indications – for chronic productive cough or wheezing; most effective in cases due to excess. + *Bai Jie Zi, Zi Su Zi* (Formula: *San zi yang qin tang*)

Jī Nèi Jīn 鸡内金 “chicken inner gold”

Endothelium Corneum Gigeriae Galli

English: chicken gizzard's internal lining

Properties: sweet, **neutral**

Channels: Bladder, Small Intestine, Spleen, Stomach

Actions and Indications

Actions: Strongly reduces food stagnation and improves the Spleen's transporting function

Indications – for various types of food stagnation; used alone for mild cases. + *Shan Zha, Mai Ya*

Actions: Consolidates the Jing (essence) and stops leakage

Indications – for bedwetting, enuresis, urination at night, and spermatorrhea.

- Enuresis: *Sang Piao Xiao, Fu Pen Zi*
- Spermatorrhea: *Lian Zi, Tu Si Zi*

Actions: Softens hardness and dissolves stones:

Indications – for stones in either the urinary or biliary tract.

Review questions:

- What herb treats food stagnation caused by eating meat?
- What herbs help alleviate food stagnation caused by starchy foods?
- What herb treats excess alcohol consumption?
- What herbs treat phlegm that obstructs the Lungs?
- What herbs stop lactation?
- What herbs treat stones?